

FIRE IS KEY IN MAYOR RACE

The Palisades blaze redefines the contest, growing the field of hopefuls against Bass.

By David Zahniser and Noah Goldberg

In some ways, it was just another campaign coffee: Los Angeles mayoral candidate Austin Beutner in a roomful of voters talking about his career and life accomplishments.

But this was no ordinary meet-and-greet. Beutner was standing inside a partially rebuilt house — with no doors, no windows and no drywall — in an area leveled by the Palisades fire. In the living room, about a dozen people spoke about what they had been through, from the frantic evacuation to the sight of smoldering ruins to the battle to get rebuilding permits.

Allison Holdorff Polhill, who owns the home, introduced Beutner — a former L.A. school superintendent — as the civic leader she would turn to first in a crisis.

“We were in the worst disaster that L.A. has ever experienced,” she told the group. “And we needed a leader that has experience with disasters and emergencies.”

The catastrophic Palisades fire, which destroyed thousands of homes and left 12 people dead, has redefined the L.A. mayor’s race, expanding the field of candidates and creating a political minefield for Karen Bass as she seeks a second four-year term.

When the fire broke out on Jan. 7, 2025, Bass drew criticism for being in Ghana on a diplomatic mission. Once she returned, she was at odds with her fire chief and unsteady in her public appearances.

More recently, she has faced scrutiny over her handling of the recovery, as well as fire officials’ watering down of an after-action report that was supposed to identify mistakes in the fire-fighting effort.

The Times found that LAFD officials failed to fully pre-deploy engines to the Palisades amid forecasts of dangerously high winds and that a battalion chief ordered firefighters to leave the scene of a Jan. 1 blaze, even though it wasn’t fully extinguished. That fire rekindled a week later to become the Palisades fire.

Fernando Guerra, a political science professor at Loyola Marymount University, said he expects the



Iranian Leader Press Office/Anadolu

SUPREME LEADER Ayatollah Ali Khamenei decried U.S. in a speech Friday.



Fars News Agency

IRANIAN DEMONSTRATORS march through downtown Tehran last week.

As protests spread, Iran intensifies its crackdown

Supreme leader denounces Trump’s threat as official likens unrest to that in U.S.

By NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei delivered a defiant speech on Friday, excoriating protesters as “saboteurs” and insisting the Islamic Republic would “not back down,” even as the country remains in the throes of a full communications blackout amid growing antigovernment demonstrations.

Speaking before a crowd that periodically broke into chants of “Death to America,” Khamenei accused protesters of working on President Trump’s behalf, saying they were acting “as mercenaries for foreigners.”

“Last night in Tehran, a bunch of vandals came and destroyed buildings that belonged to them to please the U.S. president,” Khamenei said, adding that Trump’s hands were “stained with the blood of thousands of Iranians.”

In recent days, Trump has vowed to strike Iran’s leadership if government personnel kill protesters, a threat he repeated once again in an interview with

Fox News late Thursday.

“If they do that, they’re going to have to pay hell,” Trump said, adding that the “enthusiasm to overturn that regime is incredible.”

Khamenei said Trump’s statements “emboldened rioters and elements hostile to the nation,” and that Trump would be “overthrown.”

“Were [Trump] truly capable of governing his own country,” Khamenei said, “he would have attended to its numerous internal crises.”

The unrest began a few weeks ago, with merchants and shopkeepers protesting the sharply falling value of the local currency, the rial.

[See Iran, A3]

IRAN ON EDGE: Maduro’s seizure has unnerved Tehran’s leadership. **WORLD, A3**



Allen J. Schaben Los Angeles Times

WILDFIRE RISK is as low as it gets and the year’s water supply is secure.

For the first time in 25 years, California is free of all drought

By Clara Harter

After experiencing one of the wettest holiday seasons on record, still soggy California hit a major milestone this week — having zero areas of abnormal dryness for the first time in 25 years.

The data, collected by the U.S. Drought Monitor, were welcome news for Golden State residents, who in the last 15 years alone have lived through two of the worst droughts on record, the worst wildfire seasons on record and the most destructive wildfires ever.

Right now, the wildfire risk across California is “about as close to zero as it ever gets,” and there is likely no need to worry

about the state’s water supply for the rest of the year, said UC climate scientist Daniel Swain. Currently, 14 of the state’s 17 major water supply reservoirs are at 70% or more capacity, according to the California Department of Water Resources.

California’s last drought lasted more than 1,300 days, from February 2020 to October 2023, at which point just 0.7% of the state remained abnormally dry, thanks to a series of winter atmospheric rivers that showered the Golden State with rain.

Before that, California was in a severe drought from 2012 through 2016.

But the last time 0% of the California map had any level of abnormally dry or

[See Drought, A12]

State’s budget proposal filled with volatility

An AI windfall helps narrow a projected \$3-billion deficit as negotiations kick off.

By Melody Gutierrez, Dakota Smith, Katie King and Howard Blume

SACRAMENTO — California and its state-funded programs are heading into a period of volatile fiscal uncertainty, driven largely by events in Washington and on Wall Street.

Gov. Gavin Newsom’s budget chief warned Friday that surging revenues tied to the artificial-intelligence boom are being offset by rising costs and federal funding cuts. The result: a projected \$3-billion state deficit for the next fiscal year despite no major new spending initiatives.

The Newsom administration on Friday released its proposed \$348.9-billion budget for the fiscal year that begins July 1, formally launching negotiations with the Legislature over spending priorities and policy goals.

“This budget reflects

both confidence and caution,” Newsom said in a statement. “California’s economy is strong, revenues are outperforming expectations, and our fiscal position is stable because of years of prudent fiscal management — but we remain disciplined and focused on sustaining progress, not overextending it.”

Newsom’s proposed budget did not include funding to backfill the massive cuts to Medicaid and other public assistance programs by President Trump and the Republican-led Congress, changes expected to lead to millions of low-income Californians losing healthcare coverage and other benefits.

“If the state doesn’t step up, communities across California will crumble,” California State Assn. of Counties Chief Executive Graham Knaus said in a statement.

The governor is expected to revise the plan in May using updated revenue projections after the income tax filing deadline, with lawmakers required to approve a final budget by June 15.

Newsom did not attend the budget presentation Friday, which was out of the ordinary. [See Budget, A9]



Juliana Yamada Los Angeles Times

FRANCEOLA ARMSTRONG, the mother of Keith Porter Jr., cries Monday as she embraces her cousin.

‘Active shooter’ or a victim of ICE?

Friends and family say Keith Porter Jr., killed on New Year’s Eve, didn’t pose a threat.

By James Queally, Libor Jany and Christopher Buchanan

When Adrian Metoyer first heard government officials describing his best friend as an “active shooter” and threat to his community, he was furious.

Keith Porter Jr. was a lot of things: a jack of all trades who worked dozens of jobs, a proud “girl dad” to his two daughters, an avid fisher-

man, a die-hard San Francisco 49ers fan and a “performer” who loved to drive a room to laughter with his “goofy” antics, friends and relatives said.

But, they contend, Porter wasn’t the threat Trump administration officials claimed he was after an off-duty U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agent shot and killed him in Northridge on New Year’s Eve.

“That is far from the truth. I can’t even fathom that idea of him being looked at in a negative light. Calling the officer a hero, before any investigation had been conducted ... this is ridiculous.” [See Shooting, A6]

Altadena bear saga ends with eviction

By Hannah Fry

Ken Johnson found himself in a situation that was impossible to, well, bear.

A 550-pound male black bear wedged itself into the crawl space underneath Johnson’s Altadena home just after Thanksgiving. Officials tried air horns, cherry and caramel flavored bait and even a trap that caught the wrong bear.

By Christmas, the enormous mammal had done serious damage — turning on a gas line under the house — that forced Johnson to live without hot water.

But this week, the unwelcome house guest, dubbed Yellow 2120 by researchers, finally got his formal eviction

notice. Volunteers with the BEAR League, a nonprofit based in Lake Tahoe, chased out the bear in roughly 20 minutes using paintball guns on Tuesday.

“We do a lot of evictions,” said Ann Bryant, the executive director of BEAR League. “We’re up to about 150 a year now — bears under houses, so we’re well versed on how to do it.”

It’s not a job for the faint of heart. Generally, Bryant says, the volunteer will get into the crawl space with the bear, get behind the massive animal and scare him by yelling, clapping and sometimes firing a paintball gun.

“They know they shouldn’t be there anyway, [See Bear, A9]

Firing at moving vehicles shunned

Differing from ICE policy, LAPD and other agencies say tactic puts bystanders at risk. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

X puts deepfakes behind a paywall

Musk’s Grok chatbot apologized for sexual, nonconsensual images, but subscribers keep access. **BUSINESS, A10**

Rams receivers ready to fly high

Davante Adams and Puka Nacua expect to make a difference in the wild-card clash at Carolina. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather Sunshine.

L.A. Basin: 71/49. **B8**

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